

The Year 632 CE: A Turning Point

The Death of the Prophet

- In 632 CE, Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) died in the city of Medina. He was the religious leader of Islam and the leader of the Muslim community, called the Ummah.
- After his death, Muslims had an important question:
 - **Who should lead the Muslim community now?**
 - Muhammad (PBUH) had not clearly said who the next leader should be. Muslims disagreed about the answer. This disagreement later led to the two main branches of Islam: Sunni and Shia Islam.
- Both Sunni and Shia Muslims agree that Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) was the final prophet and the original leader of the Muslim community (Ummah).

The Sunni View

Most Muslims believed the new leader should be chosen by the Muslim community. They believed the best person should lead, even if they were not part of Muhammad (PBUH)'s family.

- They chose **Abu Bakr**, who was Muhammad (PBUH)'s close friend and father-in-law.
- Abu Bakr became the first **Caliph**.
 - A Caliph is a successor or leader after Muhammad (PBUH).
- These Muslims became known as **Sunni Muslims**.
 - The name Sunni comes from the word **Sunnah**, meaning the teachings and example of Muhammad (PBUH).

The Shia View

A smaller group of Muslims believed God wanted leadership to stay within Muhammad (PBUH)'s family.

- They believed **Ali ibn Abi Talib**, Muhammad (PBUH)'s cousin and son-in-law, should become the next leader.
- Shia Muslims called their leaders **Imams**.
 - An Imam is a spiritual leader guided by God.
- These Muslims became known as **Shia Muslims**.
 - The name Shia comes from **Shi'at Ali**, meaning "Party of Ali".

Did Conflict Happen?

- At first, the disagreement was mostly peaceful, although there was tension between the groups.
 - Abu Bakr became the first Caliph. Ali later became the fourth Caliph.
- Over time, the disagreement about leadership became permanent. This created the two main branches of Islam today: Sunni Islam and Shia Islam.